In the realm of institutions, the legacy of the British Raj seems paramount. India is a strong federation with a Westminster style parliamentary form of government where the permanent bureaucracy plays a dominant role in both the making and execution of policies. The role of individuals, especially the prime minister, is reflected in decision making even where bureaucratic structures, such as cabinet committees, are ostensibly in charge.

The British institutions of governance were modelled on the feudal system of satraps that existed under India's earlier empires, especially the Mughals (1556–1857). In that system, the emperor was the *mai-baap* (literally, mother-father but figuratively 'the font of authority') or ultimate protector and benefactor. As the king sat in the capital, he was remote from the average person. The local landlord or priest, often supported by a mansabdar (imperial bureaucrat under the Mughals) enjoying the king's patronage, represented authority in India's small towns and villages. The British, starting with the East India Company, took this culture of government through patrons/benefactors down to the grass roots. Under the British, the district magistrate was both judge and collector of taxes.

Independent India inherited the British arrangement, under which every aspect of life – from schooling to health care, from law and order to infrastructure development and business – required patronage, approval or permission from a government official. India's founding fathers, including Nehru, had a paternalistic outlook and were also suspicious of market forces. While the British used their expansive bureaucracy solely for colonial advantage, Nehru and his successors concentrated powers in the hands of the bureaucracy and the state because of the belief that they knew best how to protect India's unwashed and unlettered millions.

In the field of foreign relations, this paternalism resulted in diplomacy conducted mostly outside the realm of public discussion with foreign visits put on display to show the respect and prestige of India. India's foreign